

Early plants

Plants can be divided into spore-producing plants, such as mosses and ferns, and seed-bearing plants, such as flowering plants. There are now thought to be more than 400,000 identified species. But where did they first come from?



The beginnings

Plants originated as algae—simple organisms that live in water and feed off the Sun's energy. The first algae lived in the sea. Over time, they spread into fresh water habitats and into damp places on land.



Moving onto land

More than 400 million years ago, plants started to grow on land. The first land plants were small, mosslike organisms and had no true leaves, roots, or flowers.

An unusual "seed"

Plants such as mosses and ferns have capsules that hold spores. Spores are a bit like seeds, but microscopic and not as hardy. Spores were a good means for early plants to reproduce, because an organism can produce millions of spores.

Spore-producing plants need damp conditions in which to reproduce.



Plantlike organisms flourished 420–370 million years ago. Long before the reign of the dinosaurs, Prototaxites like these could reach 26 ft (8 m) in height. It's possible these were fungi rather than plants.

Aglaphyton collected light with its entire surface. Spore-producing, egg-shaped capsules grew on its tips.

With the spread of plants, more oxygen was released into the atmosphere. Plants were changing the planet.